

POU33201: Authoritarianism

Teaching Week 2: Varieties of Autocracy

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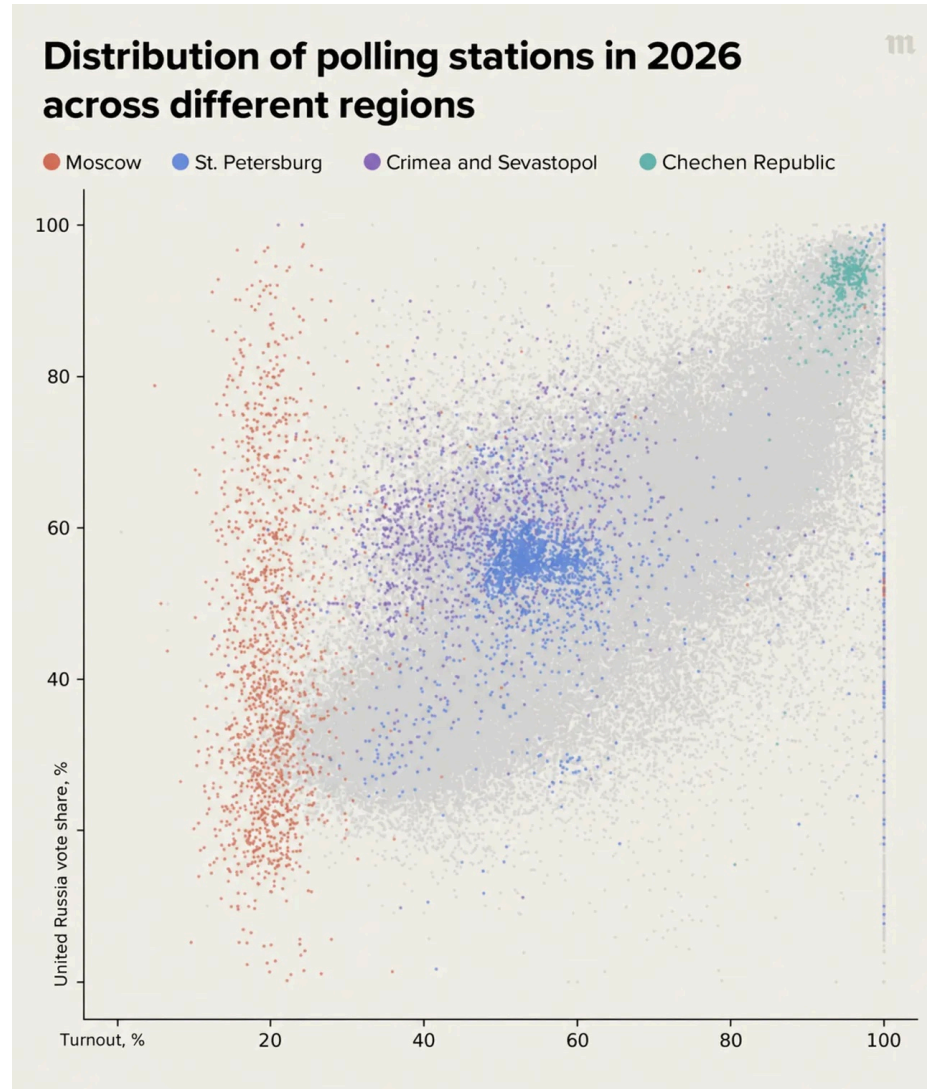
Varieties of Autocracy

Not all dictatorships are alike, and the differences matter!

Today

- **Putting regimes in boxes:** what are they for?
- **Personalism as a spectrum**, not a box: where regimes drift, and why
- **Monarchy** — the oldest (?) type of authoritarianism
- **The modal regime today isn't any of the classic four** — hybrid/electoral regimes enter the room
- **The measurement fight** — who decides what Hungary *is*?

This week in autocracy



One lens from last week was Svobik's two problems

Every dictator faces two conflicts:

- **Power-sharing:** the dictator against his own allies
- **Control:** the ruling coalition against the masses

Both are hard because “no independent third party can be realistically expected to enforce commitments among key actors”

Violence is the final arbiter, so “rules of the game” can’t be taken at face value.

And no boxes: the categories of personalist, military and single-party “are neither mutually exclusive nor collectively exhaustive”. Measure *dimensions* instead.

Svobik, *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule* (2012), ch. 1–2

Why does “type” matter at all?

Typology as a predictive *tool*, not prescriptive or infallible

Putting regimes in boxes

The core regime types:

- **Personalist** — power concentrated in one leader, thin institutions
- **Single-party** — a ruling party controls succession and access to office
- **Military** — the officer corps rules, directly or from behind a front
- **Monarchy** — hereditary, dynastic succession
- **Hybrid / electoral** — real-looking elections, an unfair playing field

GWF's payoff: type predicts survival

Geddes, Wright & Frantz didn't just classify regimes: they tracked how they *end*.

1. **Personalist regimes** — the most erratic
2. **Military regimes** — often short-lived on purpose
3. **Single-party regimes** — the most durable of all four types, by a wide margin

Putting things in boxes, but really we want to look at mechanisms underneath

Why has nobody built a new party-state since 1989?

Two things can hide inside “single-party”:

- A **party-state** — a parallel party organ shadowing every state institution; the party decides, the state implements. Lenin’s design, Stalin’s perfection, exported 1945–70.
- A **dominant-party regime** — one party wins every election, but the state is still the state. The PRI’s seventy years; Singapore’s PAP; United Russia.

Every party-state still running is a **legacy**: China, Vietnam, Cuba, Laos, North Korea

What’s missing: the ideological fuel, the wartime origins, the Soviet patron, ??.

Same tool, new lens: which problem does “type” solve?

Every week this module asks: is this an **elite-control tool** or a **mass-control tool**?

Regime type is really a **bundle of default answers** to that question, set at the moment of formation.

- **Personalist** — elite control is weak (by definition)
 - everything rests on the leader personally
- **Single-party** — elite control is institutionalised
 - the party disciplines everyone, including the leader
- **Military** — elite control runs through the officer corps’s *collective interest*
- **Monarchy** — elite control runs through kinship and dynastic hierarchy

Personalism isn't a box, more like a dial

Spectrum, typology, boxes...

The problem with the boxes

GWF's own coding puts every regime into exactly one category. But regimes **drift** and change!

A single-party regime can personalise around its leader without ever changing its formal label.

The party stays; the *substance* of power concentrates in one office, or one man.

Case: Russia's drift

A dominant-party-*adjacent* system, with United Russia, a parliament, a constitution.

Substantively: since roughly the mid-2000s, decision-making has concentrated overwhelmingly in one office.

Most serious observers now code Russia as **personalist**, not single-party, even though the party trappings never went away.

- The party exists to co-opt and channel elites, not to constrain the leader
- Succession planning is opaque and personalised: the single clearest personalist signature
- Compare early Putin (more collective, more oligarch bargaining) to Putin now



Why the spectrum matters more than the box

- The GWF survival stats (from earlier) are actually claims about **degree** of personalism, not the label
- A “single-party” regime that’s 80% personalised probably behaves like a personalist regime
 - erratic succession, leader-dependent stability
- Measuring *where on the dial* a regime sits is harder than sorting it into a box, and it’s where the live research frontier actually is (see Frantz, Kendall-Taylor and Wright on personalization)

Monarchy!

Why monarchy often gets skipped

We often spend the most time on personalist/single-party/military and wave at monarchy in one bullet

Not great! Gulf and MENA monarchies are among the **most durable** authoritarian regimes

The *mechanism* is genuinely different from the other three types.



Which monarchy?

“Monarchy” is three different things:

- **Democratic monarchy** — the crown reigns, an elected government rules. Britain, Spain, Japan. Not our subject.
- **Absolute monarchy** — the crown rules, no parliament worth the name. Saudi Arabia, pre-1789 France.
- **“Authoritarian constitutional monarchy”** — a parliament exists, elections happen, and **the king picks the prime minister**. Morocco, Jordan, Kuwait.

Two puzzles, one type

1. **Why does hereditary succession work at all** in the modern world, when it looks so fragile on paper: one bad heir away from collapse?
2. **Why are Gulf monarchies so stable**, when they have almost none of the institutional apparatus (parties, elections, ideology) the other types rely on?

Same answer to both: succession as a **focal point**, and rents that make co-optation cheap.

Brownlee + Menaldo

Brownlee: *succession* as a focal point

Why does hereditary succession actually work as a stabilising device?

A **focal point** (Schelling!): the answer everyone expects everyone else to pick. Not the best one. The obvious one.

- Elites fear a **leadership vacuum** more than they fear a mediocre heir: a clear rule beats no rule
- Hereditary succession works best when the **ruler predates the party** (or there's no party at all): nothing else is available as a focal point



Menaldo: how MENA monarchs stayed put

Victor Menaldo's puzzle: MENA monarchies survived the same 20th-century pressures (decolonisation, Arab nationalism, oil shocks) that toppled monarchies almost everywhere else.

His answer: a **political culture** (invented, not inherited) of constitutions, Islamic legitimating principles, and informal norms that gave regime insiders a durable stake in the system.



Rents make the whole thing cheap!

Gulf monarchies layer one big advantage on top of the succession focal point: **oil!** 🛢️

When the state's money comes from the ground, not from your paycheck, the state doesn't need consent so much

- Public-sector jobs, subsidies, no income tax: co-optation at scale
- This is rentier-state theory
- More in Week 5



Is Saudi Arabia just a monarchy?

Monarchy, obviously. But is that the whole story?

Quick discussion with your neighbor, 2 minutes: Saudi Arabia has a legislature (the *Majlis al-Shura*, unelected), state media, an enormous security apparatus, and a crown prince who has personalised power well beyond what “monarchy” usually implies. Does the label still fit, or is this a monarchy *drifting personalist*, the way Russia drifted the other direction?

The cases, all four together

Four countries, same trend?



- **China** — single-party, though see how personalised it's become since 2012 (drift!)
- **Saudi Arabia** — monarchy, with an active personalisation subplot (previous slide)
- **Egypt** — military-origin regime, now heavily presidentialised under al-Sisi
- **Russia** — nominally hybrid/electoral, substantively personalist

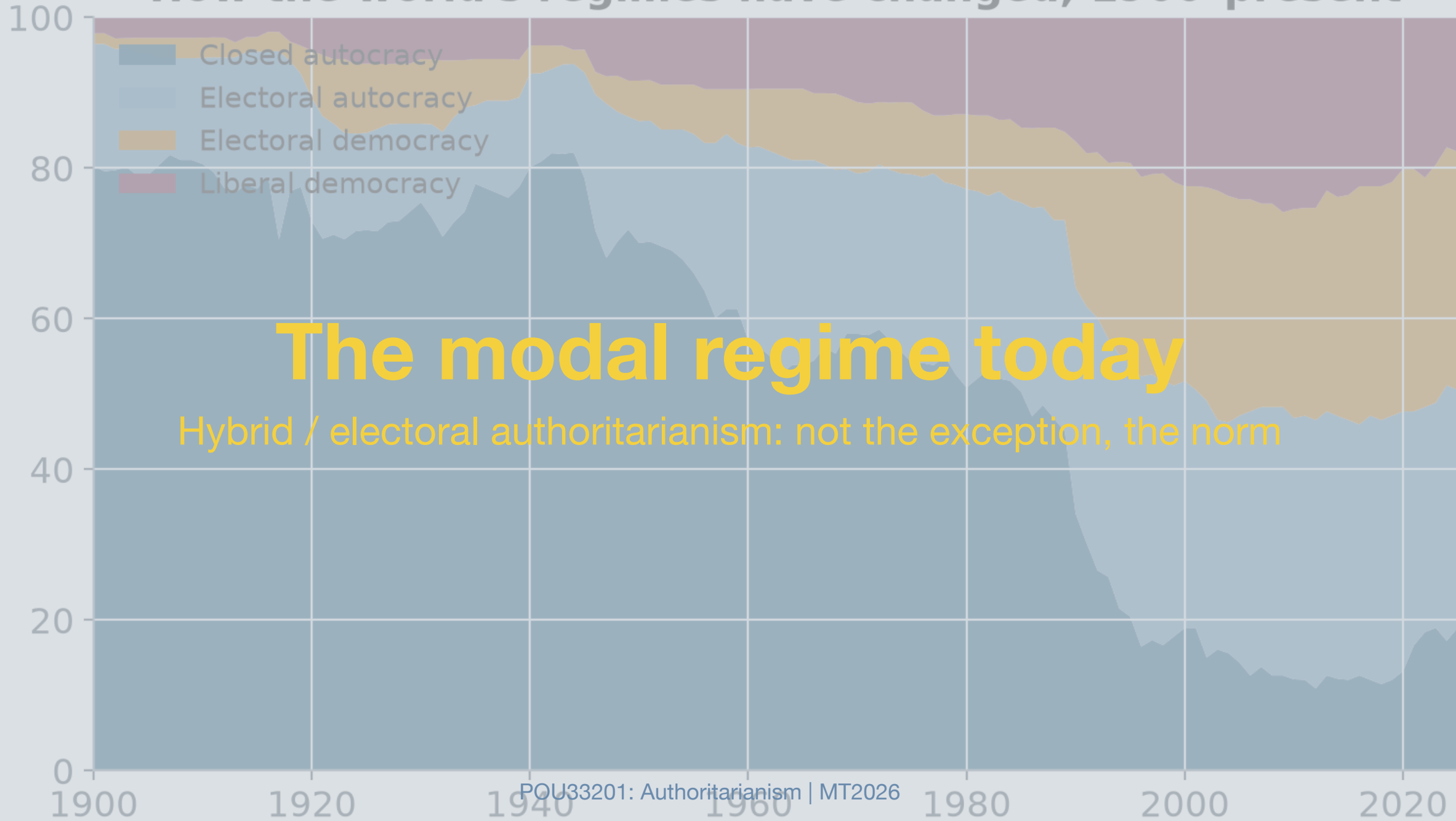
Every single one of these is more personalist than its formal label suggests. Not a coincidence, maybe?

Stump the lecturer (or the room)

Let's put regimes in boxes!

How the world's regimes have changed, 1900-present

% of countries



The slippery middle

What about regimes that hold *real-looking* elections, but rig the playing field, not just the count?

- **Electoral authoritarianism** — elections happen, opposition exists, but the terrain is tilted so far the outcome is never seriously in doubt
- **Competitive authoritarianism** (Levitsky & Way) — the opposition can compete, and occasionally even win *something*, but the deck is stacked
- Their key move: these aren't “diminished democracies” or “not-quite-there-yet”: they're a **stable regime type of their own**, not a transition stage

Why hybrid is the modal type now

Since the end of the Cold War, closed autocracy (no elections at all) has become the *minority* case.

Almost every surviving autocracy today performs some version of electoral **ritual**: Russia, Turkey, Venezuela, Cambodia, and dozens more.

- Elections generate **information** the regime actually wants (who's disloyal, who's popular)
- Elections **co-opt** the opposition into playing a game the regime controls
- Elections buy *international* **legitimacy** more cheaply than any alternative

The measurement fight

Who decides what Hungary is?

How do we even *measure* this?

V-Dem? Freedom House? Polity? GWF's own coding rules?

Every index encodes a **theory** of what democracy is. The disagreements are real!

Three indices, three theories

- **V-Dem** — thousands of country experts per country-year, aggregated by model. Where the “Regimes of the World” four-way split comes from
- **Freedom House** — its own analysts score political rights and civil liberties: Free / Partly Free / Not Free
- **Polity** — codes executive constraint and competitiveness from historical records; reaches furthest back in time

Why classification is contested

- **Concept stretching** — call too many regimes “democracy” (or “authoritarian”) and the word stops doing analytical work (Collier & Levitsky, “democracy with adjectives”)
- **Borderline cases** — where’s the actual cut-point between “flawed democracy” and “competitive autocracy”? Nobody agrees, and the cut-point changes what gets counted where
- **Regimes drift within a type** — the whole personalism-spectrum argument from earlier is itself a measurement problem: Russia 2000 ≠ Russia 2026, same formal label

Did Hungary just prove it was a democracy?

- Going into 2026: V-Dem codes Hungary an **electoral autocracy**; Freedom House, **Partly Free**
- 12 April 2026: the opposition wins **141 of 199** seats, and Orbán concedes

A democracy all along, or competitive authoritarianism working exactly as Levitsky & Way describe it?

For next week

Week 3: How Autocrats Take and Hold Power

- Geddes, Wright & Frantz, *How Dictatorships Work*, Chs. 1–2
- Svolik, *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule*, Ch. 3 (pp. 53–63)

Think about (response-paper seed): pick one of today's four cases and defend its classification against a sceptic. Then ask: which of your case's *allies* (not enemies) should the leader fear most? Hold that thought for Week 3.

See you next Friday

See you next Friday

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Slides and readings: noahbuckley.me/teaching/pou33201-mt2026

Response-paper prompt and readings for next week are on the module page.